RIGHT TRIANGLES AND PYTHAGORAS

The square of the hypotenuse of a right triangle equals the sum of the squares of the other two sides. If the shorter sides are 3 cm and 4 cm, the hypotenuse is 5 cm, because 9 + 16 = 25.

Keep the centimetre unit with each length. 5 cm is a length. 25 square centimetres is an area, not a side.

Use this to find an unknown side. If one side is 5 cm and the hypotenuse is 13 cm, the other side is 12 cm, because 25 plus the unknown square equals 169.